

WHAT IS

CONSULTATIVE PROBLEM SOLVING?

Listen. Map. Challenge.
Then recommend.

THE CORE IDEA

Make your thinking visible before you make your solution final.

Turn Discovery evidence into a recommendation your customer and Managing Director can follow.

01

EVIDENCE

02

PATTERNS

03

ROOT CAUSE

04

OPTIONS

05

PRIORITY

THINK LIKE A CONSULTANT

Do not defend your first idea. Build the strongest case.

The consultative mindset

Your strongest advantage is structured curiosity.

01

START WITH EVIDENCE

Use what the customer said, showed, measured, or experienced - not what your team assumes.

02

MAKE THINKING VISIBLE

Put ideas on the board so the team can move, compare, connect, and challenge them.

03

SEPARATE SIGNAL FROM INSIGHT

A quote is evidence. A repeated pattern is an insight. Keep the distinction clear.

04

GO BELOW THE SYMPTOM

Ask why the friction exists before deciding what capability should solve it.

05

CREATE OPTIONS

Generate multiple responses before choosing one. The first idea is rarely the only path.

06

MAKE A DEFENSIBLE CHOICE

Prioritize using customer alignment, impact, feasibility, and risk.

YOUR JOB

Make the customer's problem clearer before making the solution louder.

From signals to insights

Discovery gives you raw information. Strategize is where you decide what it means.

01

SIGNAL

A quote, observation, example, metric, or behavior.

EXAMPLE

"We copy the same information into three tools."

02

PATTERN

Several related signals point to the same recurring issue.

EXAMPLE

Duplicate work appears across multiple handoffs.

03

INSIGHT

Explain what the pattern means for the customer.

EXAMPLE

The workflow creates avoidable effort and inconsistency.

04

OPPORTUNITY

Frame where change could create value - without prescribing a feature.

EXAMPLE

Reduce repeated work while preserving necessary controls.

THE MOVE

Do not jump from a customer quote directly to a technology.

Visual problem mapping

Sticky notes are not decoration. They make team reasoning movable and visible.

01 ONE THOUGHT PER NOTE

Keep each note short enough to move, compare, and reconnect.

02 CLUSTER NATURALLY

Group related notes first. Name the pattern after it emerges.

03 DRAW CONNECTIONS

Use arrows for cause, dependency, stakeholder, sequence, or impact.

04 MARK ASSUMPTIONS

If the customer did not confirm it, label it instead of treating it as fact.

05 MOVE THINGS AROUND

Reorganizing the board is part of the thinking - not a sign you were wrong.

06 CONVERGE

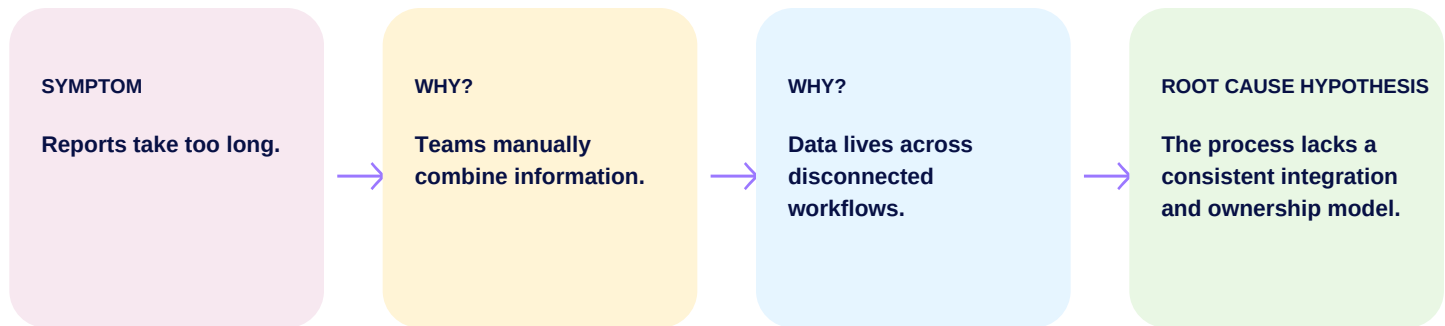
Finish with fewer, stronger ideas instead of a wall of disconnected notes.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Someone who missed the conversation can still follow your logic.

Symptoms vs. root causes

If you solve only the visible symptom, the problem may return in another form.



USE THE '5 WHYS' CAREFULLY

Keep asking what is driving the issue, but do not manufacture certainty. A root cause is still a hypothesis until Discovery evidence supports it.

BEST PRACTICE

If you are guessing, label it as an assumption and validate it.

Consultative thinking is rigorous about what is known versus what is inferred.

Diverge, then converge

Strong teams create options first, then make an explicit choice.

DIVERGE

Generate multiple ways to address the opportunity. Think about process, information flow, automation, decision support, and experience.

QUESTION

What else could solve the same underlying problem?

CONVERGE

CUSTOMER ALIGNMENT	Does it reflect Discovery?
IMPACT	Does it create meaningful value?
FEASIBILITY	Can it realistically be delivered?
RISK	What could prevent success?

REMEMBER

The goal is not the most impressive technology.

The goal is the strongest response to the customer problem.

Build the executive story

Before the SOW, your team should explain the recommendation in one connected line.



FINAL CHECK

- ✓ Can every capability trace back to Discovery?
- ✓ Can you explain why this option beat the alternatives?
- ✓ Can an executive understand the logic in under 60 seconds?

NEXT

Open the Opportunity Mapping Board.

Work through the sections with your team, screenshot the final Executive Solution Map, and place it into the Statement of Work.